# The Persecutor Becomes the Apostle

*Acts 9 · Acts 13–20 · 2 Corinthians 11:24–28*

**The big idea:** The risen Jesus stopped Saul the persecutor on the Damascus road and sent him to the nations. Paul carried the gospel through suffering, beatings, and prison, preaching the same Christ in synagogues and in Athens. If God could save Saul, no one is too far gone.

## Before you meet: Read

Acts 9:1–22 | Acts 16:11–34 | Acts 17:22–31

## Open (5 minutes)

**Who is someone you once thought would never change, who did? What happened?**

## Observe (fill in from the passage)

"Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be _____, you and your household." *(Acts 16:31)*

"I am _____, whom you are persecuting." *(Acts 9:5)*

"But by the _____ of God I am what I am." *(1 Corinthians 15:10)*

## Discuss

**1. Why do you think God chose a persecutor like Saul to be his great apostle? What does that say about grace?** *1 Timothy 1:15–16; 1 Corinthians 15:9–10*

**2. Paul preached differently in the synagogue and in Athens. What stayed the same in his message?** *Acts 13:38–39; 17:22–31*

**3. "The Lord opened her heart." What does Lydia's story tell you about how people come to faith?** *Acts 16:14*

## Memory verse

> *"The saying is trustworthy and deserving of full acceptance, that Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners, of whom I am the foremost."*
>
> **1 Timothy 1:15**

## Pray

Thank God that he saved Saul, and that he saves sinners like you. Pray by name for the person you think is least likely to come to Christ.

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# The Persecutor Becomes the Apostle

## Session plan (about 45 minutes)

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| **5 min** | Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question. |
| **10 min** | Read Acts 9:1–22 and 16:25–34 aloud together. |
| **5 min** | Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below. |
| **20 min** | Discuss: choose three of the questions. |
| **5 min** | Pray together. Introduce the memory verse and next week's reading (Acts 27–28 and Romans 1–8). |

## Main points to land

1. The risen Jesus saved Saul the persecutor and sent him to the Gentiles. No one is too far gone for grace (Acts 9:15; 1 Timothy 1:15–16).
2. Paul carried the gospel from Antioch to Rome through great suffering, and the word of God was not stopped (Acts 20:24; 28:30–31; 2 Corinthians 11:24–28).
3. Paul counted his life less precious than finishing his course and testifying to the gospel of the grace of God (Acts 20:24).

## Answer key (Observe)

1. saved
2. Jesus
3. grace

## Questions people will ask

**Why was a household baptized together in Philippi?**
Luke says Paul spoke the word of the Lord to everyone in the house, and the jailer rejoiced along with his entire household that he had believed in God (Acts 16:32–34). Where churches differ: Presbyterian, Reformed, and many other churches see here God's way of dealing with families and baptize the children of believers as part of his covenant family (Acts 2:39). Baptist and many independent churches baptize only those who profess faith for themselves. All agree that no one believes by proxy; each person must trust Christ for himself.

## Closing prayer

Lord Jesus, you stopped Saul on the road and made him a messenger of your grace. Thank you that no one is beyond your reach. Make us bold to speak of you, and patient to pray for those who seem farthest from you. Amen.